

Judge Rejects
Key Evidence
In 9/11 Case

Rules Torture Tainted
Crucial Confession

By CAROL ROSENBERG

In a major blow to the U.S. case against Khalid Shaikh Mohammed, the man accused of plotting the Sept. 11 attacks, a military judge ruled on Friday that the prisoner’s confessions to F.B.I. agents were not voluntary and cannot be used against him at trial.

Prosecutors have described Mr. Mohammed’s interrogations in 2007 at the U.S. Navy base in Guantánamo Bay, Cuba, as the government’s most crucial evidence in the long-running death-penalty case.

But his confessions have always been challenged because the government used torture to question him in secret C.I.A. prisons years before he was charged.

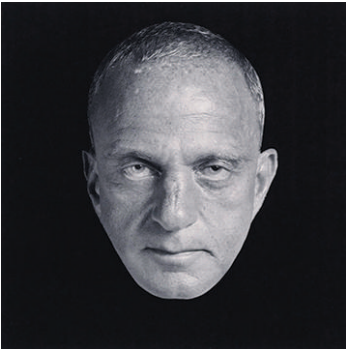
The ruling, just before the 25th anniversary of the attacks, could further delay the start of a trial if prosecutors decide to appeal to reinstate it. Aging survivors and families of victims have said they worry they may never see a final resolution to the case.

Just this week, the judge set a trial date of June 5, 2028.

Mr. Mohammed is accused of being the mastermind of the hijacking attacks that killed nearly 3,000 people in New York, Pennsylvania and the Pentagon.

He was brutally interrogated by the C.I.A. in the overseas prisons after his capture in 2003 and held incommunicado until his transfer to Guantánamo in 2006. Prosecutors excluded statements from those interrogations, which in-

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Robert Mapplethorpe’s photograph of Roy Cohn, from 1981.

Fear of Trump
Chills Nonprofit
On Cohn Book

By MICHAEL M. GRYNBAUM

It is an arresting, menacing image: the scarred face of Roy M. Cohn, the notorious New York City lawyer, fixer and master of the political dark arts, floating bodiless in a pool of black, his hooded eyes staring directly back at the viewer.

The photograph, taken by Robert Mapplethorpe in 1981, is an unforgettable depiction of its subject, and the celebrated author Kai Bird thought it would make the perfect cover art for his biography of Mr. Cohn, “American Scoundrel,” which will be released by Scribner next week.

That the picture never ended up on the book’s cover is a matter of regret to Mr. Bird — and a small but telling illustration of the anxiety that has taken root in the non-profit world because of Mr. Cohn’s most famed protégé, an ambitious real estate developer now serving his second term as president.

President Trump loomed large in the decision by the Robert Mapplethorpe Foundation, which ad-

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Clockwise from top: U.S.-Israeli airstrikes hit Tehran in March; a banner of the supreme leader, Ayatollah Ali Khamenei, who was killed at the start of the war, and his son and now successor, who was wounded; and a fruit stand. Iran’s economy remains fragile.

Bitter Debate on E.U. Pursuit
Divides Usually Genial Iceland

By AMELIA NIERENBERG and EGILL BJARNASON

TALKNAFJORDUR, Iceland — Gudlaug Bjornsdottir had warned her family. If the talk over the dinner table turned to Iceland’s coming referendum on opening talks to join the European Union, she would get up and leave.

Polls show a starkly divided country heading into the vote on Saturday. Many people have strong opinions about whether Iceland should maintain its hard-won independence or seek the stability and protections that would come with E.U. membership.

So perhaps inevitably, despite Ms. Bjornsdottir’s admonitions,

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Funding Delays Imperil Rollout
Of Mamdani’s Child Care Plan

By MATTHEW HAAG

Funding issues and late payments are threatening the rollout of Mayor Zohran Mamdani’s free child care system for 2-year-olds, two weeks before the program is scheduled to begin, day care providers said.

Many early childhood centers have yet to receive funding to buy classroom furniture and basic supplies like pencils and paper, or to pay newly hired teachers and assistants. Without the money, several providers have warned parents that the centers will not open when school starts on Sept. 10.

Because of the delays, city offi-

Many Providers Being
Asked to Front Costs

cialists had encouraged providers to apply for interest-free bridge loans from the city — not just for 2-K programs but also for 3-K and pre-K programs. But many of those who have applied for the loans say that money has not arrived either, forcing them to take out high-interest personal loans, borrow from relatives and drain their personal savings.

“Yes, they have a 2-K program, but they didn’t set up the infrastructure,” said one provider.

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THE WEATHER
Today, mostly sunny, less humid, high 80. Tonight, clear, calm winds, dry, low 65. Tomorrow, partly cloudy, more humid, light wind, dry, high 83. Weather map appears on Page B10.

NEWS ANALYSIS

Iran Defying
Might of U.S.
6 Months In

Trump Goals Distant
as Strategy Shifts

By STEVEN ERLANGER

BERLIN — It was supposed to be quick.

Still, six months after the United States and Israel launched powerful airstrikes on Iran, the conflict drags on. The Trump administration has replaced its military war with an economic one, but the result is likely to be no different, analysts said, with a lack of American clarity about goals, a decline in American credibility and a strategic defeat.

One thing remains constant, however. The ordinary people of Iran are bearing the brunt of the war, victims of both the United States and their own leaders.

On the first day of the war, Feb. 28, President Trump promised Iranians that “the hour of your freedom is at hand.” Six months later, his administration is trying to impoverish them further, hoping against hope that they will revolt and overthrow a repressive, militarized regime.

The Iranian leadership, increasingly dominated by military men, sees its own survival as the nation’s, and it considers the sacrifices of ordinary Iranians as a necessary act of patriotism and even martyrdom. It has been ever more ruthless in stamping out the slightest signs of dissent.

It is hard to dress up what has clearly been an American failure to bend Iran to its will, despite the might of the combined American and Israeli militaries. Not only has the Islamic republic survived, but it effectively controls the Strait of Hormuz. It has strengthened its influence in the region, with even the countries it was bombing a few months ago trying to reinvigorate ties with Iran.

“The war has failed to deliver U.S. objectives,” said Sanam Vakil, the director of the Middle East and North Africa program at Chatham House.

Suzanne Maloney, an Iran expert and head of foreign policy at the Brookings Institution, judged the war a failure. “We did a lot of damage to Iran, but they have come out stronger than before,” she said. Iran’s neighbors have decided they must find a modus vivendi with an Islamic republic that is not going away.

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CONFLICT’S IMPACT A look at how the markets have moved, six months into the war. PAGE B1

In House Race, 2 With Jets Ties
Give Fans Certain Win at Last

By THOMAS FULLER

SCOTTSDALE, Ariz. — “All right, I’ve had enough!” Tracy Patterson’s old-school Brooklyn accent rang out in the bar in Arizona where a New York Jets fan club had gathered to witness its team losing — again. It was the first preseason game, and the offense had already given up back-to-back interceptions.

Same old Jets.

“Here we go again,” Ms. Patterson said as she glared at the TV screens in disgust, paid her bar tab and walked out into the reddish-brown desert landscape of Maricopa County.

The fan club meets for every Jets game at the same bar, a masochistic ritual of perennial disappointment. But this season, the heavy burden of being a fan of the

Green and White comes with a twist that is proving to be a welcome distraction from the team’s consistent ranking near the bottom of the league.

It has to do with a different type of Jets contest that was set last month. Two people associated with the team — a retired kicker, Jay Feely, and a former Jets sideline doctor, Amish Shah — won their respective primaries and lined up against each other for a U.S. House seat representing the Scottsdale area, on the edge of Phoenix. Mr. Feely is a Republican, and Dr. Shah is a Democrat.

Some are calling it the doc versus the jock. But the political contest also spawned the type of dark humor that Jets fans rely on as a

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NATIONAL A9-16

Working to Anoint Successor
Representative Nancy Pelosi is rolling up her sleeves to help a little-known candidate take over her seat. PAGE A10

Ballooning Debt Elicits Shrugs
Apathy over a figure topping \$40 trillion shows how much the politics of deficit spending has changed. PAGE A13



INTERNATIONAL A4-8

Turmoil Dogs Cuban Dissident
Luis Manuel Otero Alcántara is unpacking 4,000 paintings he brought to Miami from Cuba and dodging criticism from exiles who once welcomed him. PAGE A4

An Underwater Maneuver
Despite war and looming elections, President Trump’s priority seems to be a lake. White House Memo. PAGE A8

OBITUARIES A17, 20
King of Norway for 35 Years
Harald V opened an ancient monarchy to marriages with commoners and scandals. He was 89. PAGE A20

BUSINESS B1-5

Fed Chief Addresses Inflation
In a high-profile speech, Kevin M. Warsh said that if price increases did not return quickly to the central bank’s target, “we have work to do.” PAGE B1

Trump’s Promises Falling Short
In 2024, the president promised an economic course correction. His agenda has made that fight hard. PAGE B1

TRAVEL C8-10
A Footpath Fit for a King
Paul Theroux traced the British coastline in 1982 for a book. Now he is walking a part of it again. PAGE C8

ARTS C1-6

On Tap: Grand Theft Auto VI
The game, out in November, is the series’ first release in 13 years, arriving with grander ambitions. PAGE C1

Lights, Camera, Authenticity
As a movie star, Dolly Parton was always in control of her persona, playing women who knew their value. PAGE C1



SPORTS B6-10

Belichick on Campus, Year 2
The hope that accompanied the hiring of an N.F.L. great as North Carolina coach is hard to find. PAGE B6

A Wide-Open U.S. Open
There are no clear-cut favorites in men’s or women’s singles at the year’s final major tennis tournament. PAGE B9

OPINION A18-19
Gail Collins PAGE A18

